perhaps his approach to the war in Vietnam might have been different. Perhaps. Perhaps not.

The need to avoid nuclear crises was something the Presidium took to heart. And in October 1964 Nikita Khrushchev took involuntary early retirement, though his retirement package included a pension, a car, and his *dacha* (not something that had happened with anyone taking involuntary early retirement from Stalin's Politburo). The Caribbean Crisis was one of several errors of judgement that attracted the ire of his comrades. Khrushchev's tearful rejoinder to the Presidium that all the decisions concerning Cuba (as well as those concerning Berlin, China, and much else) were collective decisions of the Presidium, cut little ice.[31]

Nikita Khrushchev learned the lesson that provoking a nuclear crisis was extremely dangerous. The most important consequence of the Cuban missile crisis was his decision to leave the West's testicles alone. Fursenko and Naftali argue, 'The Cuban missile crisis proved to be a turning point in Khrushchev's handling of Soviet foreign policy and, as a result, the Cold War.'[32] Although West Berlin's situation had not changed from when Khrushchev delivered his ultimatums, the politics had shifted. West Berlin emerged as a centrepiece of the *Ostpolitik* subsequently pursued by Chancellor Willy Brandt, the erstwhile mayor of West Berlin. The 1971 Quadripartite Berlin Agreement effectively defused the problem of Berlin's anomalous status. It was part of a broader tapestry of relations in Europe, which brought recognition of established borders, including that of the German Democratic Republic (DDR).

When Khrushchev announced the withdrawal of the missiles from Cuba, Kennedy did not expect the problem of West Berlin to go away. On 28 October 1962 he phoned Eisenhower to explain the resolution of the crisis (when he lied to Ike about the Turkish Jupiters).[33] Kennedy said it was his guess that 'by the end of next month, we're going to be toe to toe on Berlin anyway'.[34]The situation improved to the extent that JFK felt confidant to travel to West Berlin in June 1963, where he told an ecstatic crowd: *'Ich bin ein Berliner.'* Detractors claimed he or his translator erred and he announced that he was a jam doughnut. It is fair to say that the 400,000 West Berliners in the Rudolph Wilde Platz got his message.